

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Between 1854 and 1889, the keeper of the Kilmartin Point lighthouse recorded the sea temperature every morning at six o'clock, entering each reading in a leather-bound logbook alongside notes on wind, visibility, and passing vessels. Hundreds of such logbooks survive in maritime archives across northern Europe, kept by keepers who had no scientific training and no expectation that anyone would ever read their entries. Oceanographers have recently begun digitizing these records, which extend the instrumental temperature series back decades before formal ocean monitoring began and allow researchers to reconstruct patterns of coastal warming with unusual precision.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It profiles a lighthouse keeper, describes the daily responsibilities of his position, and then argues that his contribution has been unfairly forgotten.
- B: It identifies a gap in historical ocean temperature data, evaluates several methods of filling that gap, and then recommends the most reliable one.
- C: It presents a scientific technique, traces its development in northern Europe, and then describes its application to a newly available type of archive.
- D: It describes one historical record, situates it within a larger body of similar records, and then explains the scientific use researchers now make of them.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Watch the zoom level: one dated logbook -> "Hundreds of such logbooks" -> what scientists do with them.

Trick: when a text opens with a very specific date and place, check whether the next sentence widens the frame. Narrow to wide to present-day use is a standard DSAT opener.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Why do the flowers of the Sonoran night-blooming cereus open only after dark, and only for a single night each year? One possibility is that darkness protects the delicate petals from desiccation in desert heat. Another is that nocturnal opening reduces competition for pollinators, since comparatively few plants bloom at night. Botanist Renata Oyelaran favors a third explanation: the cereus depends almost entirely on a single species of hawkmoth that forages after sunset, and the plant's bloom time tracks the moth's activity window so closely that even a two-hour shift would leave the flowers unvisited.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It poses a question, surveys several possible answers, and then identifies the explanation that one researcher considers most persuasive.

B: It describes a rare desert plant, explains the conditions required for its survival, and then warns that those conditions are increasingly threatened.

C: It presents a widely accepted explanation for a phenomenon, introduces evidence against it, and then proposes a replacement explanation.

D: It compares two desert species, identifies an unusual trait they share, and then accounts for the evolutionary origin of that trait.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Sentence 1 ends in a literal question mark. Then count the candidates: "One possibility... Another... a third explanation." Trick: a question in the opening line plus an enumerated list of answers is a question-and-candidates structure, and the researcher named last is the author's pick.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Urban pigeons navigate home from unfamiliar release sites with an accuracy that has long puzzled researchers, since the birds appear to lack the extended flight experience that trained homing pigeons acquire. Early hypotheses invoked magnetic sensitivity or an unusually refined sense of smell. Recent tracking work by ornithologist Petra Aalto suggests a far simpler account: city pigeons follow major roads. Aalto's GPS data show birds tracing highway routes and turning at intersections, sometimes adding considerable distance to their journeys rather than flying directly toward home. The apparent navigational feat, she concludes, reflects familiarity with human infrastructure rather than any exotic sensory capacity.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes an animal behavior, attributes it to a specialized sensory ability, and then explains how that ability likely evolved.
- B: It introduces a research method, demonstrates its advantages over earlier methods, and then applies it to a longstanding scientific debate.
- C: It compares wild and trained pigeons, identifies a difference in their navigational accuracy, and then accounts for that difference.
- D: It presents a puzzling ability, notes the elaborate explanations previously offered for it, and then reports a more ordinary explanation supported by new data.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: "A far simpler account" is the hinge. Exotic explanations get replaced by a mundane one. Trick: words like "simpler," "more ordinary," or "less exotic" signal deflation, so the correct option should describe the new explanation as ordinary rather than sophisticated.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: When soils warm, microbes decompose organic matter faster, releasing carbon dioxide. Some ecologists predicted this would create a runaway feedback in which warming drives ever-increasing emissions; others expected microbial communities to acclimate within a few years, returning emissions to their original baseline. A twenty-six-year heating experiment in a Massachusetts forest produced neither result. Emissions surged for roughly a decade, subsided as the most accessible carbon was exhausted, and then surged again as microbial communities reorganized to exploit more resistant compounds. The soil has cycled through alternating phases rather than settling into either the runaway or the stable pattern that had been anticipated.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a long-term experiment, reports its findings, and then explains why those findings confirm an earlier prediction.
- B: It presents two opposing predictions about a process, describes a long-term test of those predictions, and then reports an outcome matching neither.
- C: It identifies an environmental problem, evaluates two proposed solutions, and then recommends combining them.
- D: It traces the history of a research program, notes a methodological improvement, and then summarizes the resulting scientific consensus.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Produced neither result" does all the work. Trick: when a text names two expectations and then explicitly rejects both, the structure is prediction-prediction-surprise. Options claiming the data confirmed a prediction are dead on arrival.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: A single *Temnothorax* ant, removed from its colony and placed in an arena, wanders with no apparent purpose, revisiting the same corners and failing to locate food placed only a few centimeters away. Its individual capacities are modest: a short memory, a limited visual field, and no representation of the arena as a whole. Yet a colony of two hundred such ants, exploring the same arena, locates the food within minutes and recruits nestmates along an efficient route. Entomologists studying the species argue that colony-level competence emerges from the interaction of individually limited agents rather than from any single ant's understanding of the task.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It describes an individual organism's limitations, contrasts them with the capabilities of the group, and then explains how group capability arises.

B: It introduces a species, describes its characteristic foraging behavior, and then compares that behavior with that of a related species.

C: It defines a biological term, illustrates the term with a laboratory example, and then argues that the term should be applied more broadly.

D: It presents an experimental setup, identifies a flaw in that setup, and then describes how researchers corrected the flaw.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The unit of analysis shifts from one ant to two hundred, and "Yet" marks the shift. Trick: when the grammatical subject changes from singular to collective partway through, expect an individual-versus-group structure and check that the answer captures both levels.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Seismologists developed ambient noise tomography to image the Earth's interior using the faint, continuous vibrations produced by ocean waves and passing traffic, extracting structure from signals that had previously been discarded as background interference. Glaciologist Marcus Ihejirika realized the same principle could be applied to ice. By placing sensor arrays on the surface of a Greenland glacier and analyzing its ambient hum, Ihejirika's team produced detailed maps of internal meltwater channels without drilling a single borehole. The approach, borrowed wholesale from a neighboring discipline, has since been adopted by researchers studying ice sheets in Antarctica.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It presents a scientific instrument, explains the physical principles by which it operates, and then argues that it should be more widely available.

B: It describes a glaciological problem, reviews several methods of addressing it, and then identifies the least invasive of those methods.

C: It introduces a technique developed in one field, describes its transfer to a different field, and then notes the technique's further spread.

D: It traces the history of a scientific discipline, identifies its founding insight, and then evaluates that insight's continuing relevance.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The text says it outright: "borrowed wholesale from a neighboring discipline." Trick: origin field, new field, wider adoption. When a passage names two different sciences in sequence, check whether the second is importing a tool from the first rather than competing with it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Svalbard Global Seed Vault stores duplicate samples of crop seeds from gene banks worldwide inside a tunnel bored into Arctic permafrost. <u>If a regional gene bank is destroyed by war, flood, or funding collapse, the varieties it held would otherwise be lost permanently, along with the genetic traits that breeders draw on to develop crops resistant to emerging diseases.</u> The vault's operators do not treat the facility as a research site; no one studies the seeds stored there, and the collection generates no publications. It functions instead as insurance, opened only when a depositor requests the return of material it can no longer obtain anywhere else.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It explains what would be at risk in the vault's absence, establishing why the facility exists.
- B: It presents an objection to the vault's funding model that the remainder of the text rebuts.
- C: It describes the specific engineering features that allow the vault to preserve seeds over long periods.
- D: It identifies a limitation of the vault's design that the text goes on to address.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The pattern "If X happens, Y would otherwise be lost" is stakes-setting. Trick: a conditional clause describing a disaster that the subject prevents is explaining why the subject matters. The rest of the text says what the vault is; the underlined line says why anyone bothered.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The fragment of parchment now catalogued as Beinecke MS 1108 is the earliest surviving copy of a Middle Irish legal tract previously known only from seventeenth-century transcriptions. It reached that status by an unlikely route. Conservators removing the binding of a sixteenth-century printed book found the parchment folded inside the spine, where a binder had used it as stiffening material. Ultraviolet imaging then recovered text that had been scraped away and overwritten, and paleographers dated the underlying script to the eleventh century. The tract's language, it turned out, was several centuries older than the transcriptions on which all previous scholarship had relied.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a conservation technique, explains the principles behind it, and then reports its most significant application to date.
- B: It introduces a genre of medieval writing, describes its typical features, and then identifies an unusual surviving example.
- C: It presents a scholarly dispute about a text's date, summarizes the evidence on each side, and then resolves the dispute.
- D: It states the significance of a manuscript, and then recounts the sequence of discoveries that established that significance.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Sentence 1 announces the result; sentence 2 promises the backstory ("reached that status by an unlikely route"). Trick: when an early sentence points backward in time, the passage is running result-then-explanation, not straight chronology.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: For decades, sleep researchers held that memory consolidation occurs primarily during slow-wave sleep, when the hippocampus replays the day's experiences for transfer to the cortex. A series of studies in the 2010s complicated this account: participants deprived selectively of REM sleep showed impairments in emotional and procedural memory that slow-wave sleep did not prevent, and some researchers argued that the field had overinvested in a single sleep stage. More recent work using simultaneous recordings from both regions suggests that the two stages perform distinct and sequential operations, with slow-wave sleep stabilizing new memories and REM sleep integrating them into existing knowledge. The original emphasis on slow-wave sleep, on this account, was incomplete rather than mistaken.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a longstanding view, reports findings that challenged it, and then presents newer work suggesting the original view was partial rather than wrong.
- B: It contrasts two stages of sleep, explains the function of each, and then argues that one is considerably more important for memory than the other.
- C: It identifies a methodological problem in sleep research, describes an improved technique, and then reports that technique's first results.
- D: It presents a scientific consensus, describes the evidence that established it, and then argues that the consensus should be abandoned entirely.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The last sentence decides it: "incomplete rather than mistaken." Trick: when the closing line partially rescues the original position, the arc is consensus, challenge, partial vindication. Options saying the consensus was abandoned overshoot.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Whether a given parcel of land counts as a wetland depends on which of several competing definitions is applied. Hydrologists generally require sustained saturation of the soil; botanists look for plant species adapted to waterlogged conditions; soil scientists examine the chemical signatures left by periodic flooding. A parcel that satisfies one criterion may fail another, particularly in landscapes that flood seasonally. The disagreement is not merely terminological. In jurisdictions where wetlands receive statutory protection, the definition adopted by a regulatory agency determines which parcels may be drained and developed, and shifts in that definition have moved millions of acres into and out of protected status without any change to the land itself.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a natural feature, explains its ecological importance, and then advocates for stronger legal protection of such features.
- B: It defines a scientific term, traces the term's historical origin, and then argues that the term has become outdated.
- C: It presents several competing definitions of a category, notes that they can conflict, and then explains why the conflict has practical consequences.
- D: It compares three scientific disciplines, identifies their differing methods, and then proposes a framework for integrating those methods.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "The disagreement is not merely terminological" is the pivot to real-world stakes. Trick: when a text insists a dispute is "not merely" academic, everything after that sentence explains the consequences, so the correct structure must include a consequences beat.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: A widely cited 2011 experiment reported that a particular ruthenium catalyst converted carbon dioxide to formate at yields far exceeding those of any known alternative. Several laboratories subsequently failed to reproduce the result, and for some years the finding was regarded as an anomaly of uncertain origin. Chemist Ingrid Sowande eventually traced the discrepancy to the original team's use of glassware that had previously held a zinc compound; trace zinc residue, not the ruthenium catalyst, was driving the reaction. The original yields were entirely real, Sowande notes, but the mechanism responsible had been misidentified, and the accidental contamination has since become the basis of a deliberately designed zinc-ruthenium system.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a chemical reaction, identifies the catalyst responsible for it, and then explains why that catalyst is difficult to synthesize.
- B: It presents a case of scientific misconduct, traces how the misconduct was discovered, and then discusses reforms adopted in response.
- C: It reports an experimental finding, describes failed attempts to reproduce it, and then explains how those failures led to a corrected account and a new application.
- D: It introduces a laboratory technique, compares it with older techniques, and then argues that it produces more reliable results.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "The yields were entirely real... but the mechanism had been misidentified." Trick: separate "the result was wrong" from "the explanation was wrong." Contamination discovered by accident and then put to use is a correction story, not a fraud story.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Urban rewilding projects, which convert intensively maintained parkland into self-regulating habitat, have expanded rapidly across European cities over the past decade. Critics contend that such projects sacrifice recreational space that dense neighborhoods can ill afford to lose. Advocates respond that rewilded sites are rarely closed to the public, and that most schemes convert mown grass verges and roundabout interiors rather than playing fields or playgrounds. The evidence on ecological outcomes is considerably more mixed: invertebrate diversity rises quickly at nearly every site, but bird and mammal populations show measurable gains only where rewilded patches connect to larger green corridors.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It introduces the ecological evidence that the remainder of the text evaluates in detail.
- B: It provides a specific example of a rewilding project that failed to achieve its stated aims.
- C: It concedes that critics of rewilding have correctly identified the projects' central drawback.
- D: It answers a criticism raised in the preceding sentence before the text turns to a separate issue.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: "Advocates respond" sits directly after "Critics contend," so it closes that exchange. Trick: check what comes next. The following sentence starts a new topic ("evidence on ecological outcomes"), which proves the underlined line ended the previous argument rather than introducing the new one.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: When national nutrition standards for school meals were revised in 2012, they required a minimum serving of vegetables at every lunch. Compliance rates reported by districts approached ninety percent within two years. Plate-waste studies, however, found that a substantial share of the required servings went uneaten, and in some districts vegetable consumption did not rise at all despite full compliance. Subsequent revisions shifted the requirement from servings offered to servings selected, permitted districts to substitute preparations that students were more likely to eat, and funded kitchen equipment that made fresh preparation feasible. Consumption, rather than compliance, became the outcome that the standards were written to measure.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It introduces a policy, reports that formal compliance failed to produce the intended effect, and then describes how the policy was redesigned in response.
- B: It presents a public health problem, identifies its primary cause, and then evaluates several proposed remedies for it.
- C: It compares nutrition standards across several countries, identifies the most effective approach, and then recommends its wider adoption.
- D: It describes a nutritional guideline, explains the scientific research supporting it, and then argues that the guideline should be strengthened.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Ninety percent compliance, but the food went uneaten. Trick: watch for a gap between following the rule and achieving the goal, then notice the metric changing in the final line. A changed measure at the end is the signature of a redesign structure.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: White-crowned sparrows sing in distinct regional dialects, and young males acquire the dialect of the territory where they are raised rather than that of their fathers. Researchers have generally treated this as evidence that song is learned through exposure during a critical period early in life. Sparrows hand-reared in acoustic isolation and played recordings of a foreign dialect during that period reproduce the foreign dialect faithfully, even though no adult of that population is ever present. The finding rules out explanations based on social interaction with a live tutor and locates the mechanism in auditory exposure alone.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It describes the typical process by which sparrows in the wild acquire their regional dialect.
- B: It presents a case that isolates a single variable and thereby narrows the range of possible explanations.
- C: It identifies an exception to the critical-period account that researchers have not yet explained.
- D: It offers an anecdote illustrating the difficulty of raising sparrows under laboratory conditions.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The very next sentence states the job: it "rules out explanations based on social interaction." Trick: an experimental setup that strips away one factor exists to eliminate a rival explanation. It is never there just to describe what normally happens.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Proponents of asteroid mining often begin with an arresting figure: a single metallic asteroid a kilometer across might contain more platinum-group metal than has been extracted in all of human history. If such material could be returned to Earth, the argument runs, scarcity in these metals would simply end. Economists examining the proposition note that the figure describes gross content rather than recoverable yield, and that returning even modest tonnages would require propulsion capacity that does not currently exist. More decisively, delivering platinum in the quantities described would collapse its price well below the cost of retrieval. The scenario is not so much technically premature as economically self-defeating.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a technological obstacle, reviews attempts to overcome it, and then predicts when it will be resolved.
- B: It introduces an economic principle, illustrates it with a hypothetical case, and then applies it to an existing industry.
- C: It presents an ambitious proposal, examines the assumptions and figures behind it, and then concludes that the proposal fails on its own terms.
- D: It compares terrestrial and extraterrestrial mining, identifies the advantages of each, and then recommends a combined approach.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "More decisively" flags the knockout objection, and the closing line says the plan defeats itself. Trick: distinguish an external obstacle (we lack the technology) from an internal contradiction (success would destroy the payoff). The last sentence tells you which one the text is arguing.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Coffee farms that retain a canopy of shade trees suffer markedly lower rates of coffee leaf rust than farms cultivated in full sun, a pattern documented consistently across Central America. Shade lowers leaf-surface temperature and slows the drying of dew, conditions under which the rust fungus germinates poorly and its spores disperse less readily on air currents. The relationship is not without cost: shaded farms yield less per hectare in years without outbreaks, and growers therefore face a choice between lower average yields and lower variability in yields.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It states the central recommendation that the text makes to coffee growers.
- B: It introduces a drawback of shade cultivation that the text goes on to quantify.
- C: It explains the physical process that accounts for the association described in the preceding sentence.
- D: It defines a technical term that is necessary for understanding the rest of the passage.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Sentence 1 gives a correlation, the underlined sentence gives the how. Trick: if a sentence answers "why does that association exist," its function is mechanism. Note also that the drawback appears after the underlined portion, not inside it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Lake Vostok lies beneath nearly four kilometers of Antarctic ice, where temperatures should freeze any body of water solid. That it remains liquid puzzled glaciologists for years after seismic surveys established its existence. Two factors account for the anomaly. Geothermal heat rising from the bedrock warms the lake from below, and the immense weight of the overlying ice depresses the freezing point of water by several degrees. Neither factor alone would suffice; acting together, they maintain the lake in a liquid state that has persisted, sealed off from the atmosphere, for something on the order of fifteen million years.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a geographic feature, explains the method used to detect it, and then discusses what its study might eventually reveal.
- B: It presents an apparent anomaly, and then identifies the combination of factors that resolves it.
- C: It traces the formation of a landform, describes its subsequent changes over time, and then predicts its future state.
- D: It introduces a scientific controversy, summarizes the positions taken by each side, and then declines to adjudicate between them.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Should freeze" followed by "that it remains liquid puzzled" sets up the anomaly; "Two factors account for the anomaly" resolves it. Trick: the word "should" paired with a contrary fact is an anomaly signal, and what follows will be the explanation, not a debate.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The Elwha River restoration removed two hydroelectric dams that had blocked salmon migration for a century. Early reporting focused on the speed with which sediment cleared and vegetation colonized the drained reservoir beds. Fisheries biologists, however, have argued that the project should be evaluated by whether salmon populations become self-sustaining without hatchery supplementation, a threshold that cannot be assessed for at least two decades. By that measure, results so far are encouraging but preliminary: several species have recolonized upstream reaches, though the proportion of naturally spawned returns remains below pre-dam estimates.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It explains the technical process by which sediment cleared from the former reservoir beds.
- B: It reports the most significant finding to emerge from the restoration project so far.
- C: It raises a criticism of the decision to remove the dams that the text subsequently rebuts.
- D: It specifies the standard by which the project's success should be judged, a standard the text then applies.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The next sentence opens "By that measure," which proves the underlined portion supplied the measure. Trick: always read one sentence past the underline. If the following sentence applies a yardstick, the underlined text is where that yardstick was set.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: During eighteen months in an Andean market town, anthropologist Verena Kolb recorded what she initially classified as bargaining: extended exchanges between vendors and regular customers over prices that, she eventually realized, almost never changed. The final figure was fixed by long-standing convention; what varied was the length and warmth of the exchange preceding it. Kolb argues that her early coding scheme had imported an assumption -- that talk about price constitutes negotiation -- which the setting did not support, and that she detected the error only because the price data were flat enough to be conspicuous. Ethnographic categories, she concludes, are most dangerous when they are plausible enough to seem observational rather than interpretive.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a market economy, identifies an unusual pricing custom, and then compares that custom with practices documented elsewhere.
- B: It recounts a researcher's fieldwork error, explains how she came to detect it, and then draws a general methodological lesson from the episode.
- C: It summarizes an anthropological debate about bargaining, presents evidence for each position, and then endorses one of them.
- D: It criticizes an established research method, proposes an alternative to it, and then demonstrates the alternative's superiority.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Track the subject of the final sentence: it jumps from Kolb to "ethnographic categories" in general. Trick: when the last line widens from one researcher's experience to the whole discipline, the structure ends in a general lesson, not a comparison or a debate.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The typeface designed for the 1968 Mexico City Olympics extended a single identity program across signage, tickets, and stadium graphics, its concentric-line motif derived from Huichol yarn painting and from the Op Art of the period. Applied at large scale to venue exteriors, the lettering resolved into pure pattern at a distance and into legible text up close. <u>What distinguishes the program from the corporate identity systems that followed it is that its visual language was not merely applied to a place but derived from one.</u> Later Olympic identities have generally reversed this relationship, selecting a national motif and imposing it on a modular grid developed independently of any particular site.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It provides additional historical detail about the sources from which the typeface was derived.
- B: It restates the technical claim of the preceding sentence in more accessible language.
- C: It concedes a shortcoming of the 1968 identity program before the text moves to defend it.
- D: It shifts the text from describing the design program to assessing what sets it apart from later work.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: "What distinguishes X is..." is an evaluative frame, not a descriptive one. Trick: the first half of the passage says what the design looked like; the underlined line begins saying why it matters. That is a description-to-evaluation pivot.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The disappearance of large mammals from Australia around forty-five thousand years ago has been attributed both to human arrival and to a period of intensified aridity, and the evidence is genuinely ambivalent: the two events overlap within the resolution of available dating, and each mechanism predicts sustained population decline. Paleoecologist Nadia Bhatt notes that the hypotheses diverge in one respect that has not been exploited. Climate-driven decline should appear first and most severely in the arid interior, whereas hunting-driven decline should track the coastal routes along which people are thought to have moved. Bhatt argues that a sufficiently dense grid of dated remains, organized geographically rather than chronologically, could distinguish the two.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It presents a historical controversy, evaluates the evidence for each side, and then concludes that one explanation is better supported.
- B: It describes two competing explanations, notes that existing evidence cannot separate them, and then identifies a difference in their predictions that a new approach could test.
- C: It traces the extinction of a group of species, describes the ecological effects of that extinction, and then discusses efforts to reverse them.
- D: It identifies a limitation of radiocarbon dating, explains its consequences for paleoecology, and then proposes an alternative dating method.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Diverge in one respect that has not been exploited" is the giveaway. Trick: when both explanations fit the current data equally well, the correct answer proposes a way to tell them apart, not a winner. Bhatt never picks a side.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Transplanting gut microbiota from lean mice into germ-free recipients has repeatedly been shown to confer resistance to weight gain, a result that has driven considerable interest in microbial therapies for human metabolic disease. <u>These experiments are conducted in animals raised without any microbiota at all, on rigidly controlled diets, and with donor and recipient sharing a genetic background -- conditions that no human recipient approximates.</u> Human trials have accordingly produced smaller and far less consistent effects, and the few that report metabolic improvement typically involve recipients whose existing microbial communities had been substantially depleted by prior antibiotic treatment.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It describes the experimental procedure by which microbiota are transferred between animals.
- B: It identifies features of the animal experiments that limit how far their results extend to humans.
- C: It summarizes the principal finding that the human trials described later went on to confirm.
- D: It proposes a specific modification to the design of future human trials.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Conditions that no human recipient approximates" is a scope limit, and the next sentence begins "accordingly," confirming the consequence. Trick: a sentence cataloguing how artificial a study was exists to restrict generalization, even though it reads like a neutral method description.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Medieval European medical texts prescribe treatments that later readers found absurd, among them a salve of onion, garlic, wine, and ox bile applied to eye infections. A team of microbiologists reconstructed the preparation in 2015 and found that it killed methicillin-resistant *Staphylococcus aureus* in laboratory culture more effectively than several modern antibiotics, a result that circulated widely as vindication of premodern medicine. Historian Alicia Fenwick cautions against that framing. The same manuscripts prescribe the salve for conditions it could not possibly have treated, and their compilers had no concept of bacterial infection; efficacy in a single case reflects the empirical accumulation of recipes rather than an understanding that modern testing has now confirmed.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes a historical practice, reports modern evidence of its effectiveness, and then questions the interpretation that evidence has been given.
- B: It compares medieval and modern medicine, identifies the principal differences, and then argues that the two are more similar than is generally assumed.
- C: It presents a scientific finding, traces its influence on public opinion, and then describes attempts to replicate it.
- D: It introduces a manuscript tradition, explains how such texts were compiled, and then discusses their preservation.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Fenwick "cautions against that framing" -- she targets the interpretation, not the lab result. Trick: separate "the finding is wrong" from "the meaning attached to the finding is wrong." She never disputes that the salve worked in culture.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Between roughly 1400 and 1700, the long vowels of English shifted position systematically, a change ordinarily attributed to internal pressures within the sound system itself. Contact with immigrant populations in London during the same period has been proposed as a trigger, and the timing is certainly suggestive. But the shift proceeded in regions with negligible immigration, and its stepwise character -- each vowel raising as the one above it moved out of position -- is difficult to reconcile with an external cause. Most historical linguists therefore treat the London evidence as coincidental rather than causal.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It introduces an alternative explanation, granted some initial plausibility, that the text then argues against.
- B: It presents the explanation for the vowel shift that most historical linguists currently accept.
- C: It provides evidence that immigration to London accelerated a sound change already under way.
- D: It defines the phenomenon that the remainder of the text goes on to describe in detail.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: "The timing is certainly suggestive" grants plausibility; the very next word is "But." Trick: a rival explanation given a fair hearing immediately before a contrast word is being set up for dismissal. Generosity toward an idea is not endorsement of it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: New Caledonian crows manufacture hooked tools from twigs, selecting suitable materials and trimming them to shape, and researchers have often described the behavior as evidence of mental representation of the finished tool. Auguste Lenoir's recent analysis complicates that reading. Crows in his study produced functional hooks with roughly equal success whether working from familiar plant material or from unfamiliar wire, but the sequence of their actions differed sharply: with wire, the birds proceeded by iterative adjustment, testing the tool repeatedly against the task and modifying it after each failure. The outcome is the same, Lenoir argues, but the process points toward feedback-driven refinement rather than execution of a preconceived design.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It describes an animal behavior, presents evidence that the behavior is more sophisticated than had been assumed, and then discusses the implications.
- B: It compares two species of tool-using birds, identifies a difference in their methods, and then accounts for that difference.
- C: It reports a widely accepted interpretation of a behavior, presents findings consistent with a less demanding explanation, and then articulates that alternative.
- D: It introduces a research method, explains why it is superior to observational study, and then reports its principal finding.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "The outcome is the same... but the process points toward" a simpler mechanism. Trick: when new evidence preserves the behavior but downgrades the mental machinery behind it, look for "less demanding explanation." Options claiming greater sophistication run the wrong direction.

END QUESTION